Pi-hole Watchdog: The Beginner's Guide

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This adds a "smoke detector" to your Pi-hole. If something goes wrong, your phone gets a message telling you what happened and how to fix it. No experience needed: follow the parts in order, about 20 minutes start to finish.

What you'll need

- [ ] Your **Raspberry Pi with Pi-hole** already set up and working (ads are already being blocked)
- [ ] A **Windows computer** on the same home network as the Pi
- [ ] Your **phone**
- [ ] The file **pihole-watchdog-install.sh**, which came with this guide
- [ ] The Pi's **username and password**, the ones you created when you set up the Pi. On older Pis the username is often `pi`.

You won't need to write any code. You'll copy and paste a few short lines, and every line you need is printed in this guide.

Words you'll see

Word	What it means
Pi	Your Raspberry Pi, the little computer running Pi-hole
IP address	The Pi's "house number" on your network, like `192.168.1.82`
SSH	A way to type commands into the Pi from your computer
PuTTY	A free Windows program for SSH. It opens a black window where you type commands.
WinSCP	A free Windows program for copying files onto the Pi by dragging and dropping

Word	What it means
Command	A line of text you paste into the PuTTY window, then press Enter
sudo	Put in front of a command to run it as the boss. The Pi asks for your password.
ntfy	A free phone app (say "notify") that receives the alerts
Channel	Your private ntfy address. Only someone who knows the name can see your alerts.

Part 1: Put the ntfy app on your phone

1. Open the **Play Store** (Android) or **App Store** (iPhone).
2. Search for **ntfy** and install it. It's free, and you don't need an account.
3. Open it once, allow notifications if it asks, then leave it alone for now. You'll come back to it in Part 5.

Part 2: Find your Pi and log in with PuTTY

Find the Pi's IP address. Use whichever of these is easiest:

- It's the numbers in the web address you use for the Pi-hole dashboard, for example `http://192.168.1.82/admin`.
- Or open your router's app or web page, look at the list of connected devices, and find one called **pihole** or **raspberrypi**.

Write it down. You'll use it several times.

Log in with PuTTY:

1. If you don't have PuTTY, download it from **putty.org** and install it.
2. Open PuTTY. In **Host Name**, type the Pi's IP address. Leave Port as 22 and Connection type as SSH. Click **Open**.
3. The first time, a **Security Alert** pops up asking whether you trust this computer. Click **Accept**. This is normal.
4. A black window opens. At **login as:**, type the Pi's username and press Enter.

5. Type the password and press Enter. **Nothing shows while you type it, not even dots.** That's normal. Just type it and press Enter.

You're in when you see a line ending in `$`, like `pi@pihole:~ $`. Leave this window open.

Two PuTTY tips:

- To paste into PuTTY, **right-click** inside the window. Ctrl+V does not work there.
- After pasting a line, press **Enter** to run it.

Part 3: Copy the installer file onto the Pi

You'll drag the file from your computer onto the Pi with a free program called WinSCP.

1. Save **pihole-watchdog-install.sh** somewhere easy, like your Desktop. **Don't open it in Notepad and save it.** That can quietly break it.
2. Download **WinSCP** from **winscp.net** and install it.
3. Open WinSCP. A login box appears. Fill it in:
   - **File protocol:** SFTP
   - **Host name:** the Pi's IP address
   - **User name** and **Password:** the Pi's username and password
4. Click **Login**. If it asks whether you trust the server, click **Yes** or **Accept**.
5. You'll see two sides. The **left** is your computer and the **right** is the Pi. Don't change folders on the right side.
6. On the left, find **pihole-watchdog-install.sh** and **drag it to the right side**. Click **OK** if it asks to confirm.

When the file shows up on the right side, it's on the Pi. You can close WinSCP.

Part 4: Run the installer

1. Go back to the PuTTY window.
2. Copy this line, right-click in PuTTY to paste it, and press **Enter**:

```
bash pihole-watchdog-install.sh
```

3. If it asks for your password, type it (invisible again) and press Enter.
4. After a few seconds, a box like this appears:

```
================================================
  Your ntfy channel name:  pihole-k3x9q2m7w1ab
  Router: 192.168.1.1    This Pi: 192.168.1.82    Unbound: yes
================================================
```

Write down your channel name exactly (yours will be different from the example). It's the address your alerts go to.

If you see a line starting with **NOTE**, that's fine. Part 6 takes care of it.

Part 5: Connect your phone and test it

1. Open **ntfy** on your phone and tap the **+** button.
2. Type your channel name from Part 4 **exactly**, then tap **Subscribe**.
3. In PuTTY, paste this line and press **Enter**:

```
sudo pihole-watchdog.sh test
```

4. Within a few seconds your phone should show **"Pi-hole watchdog: Test message - alerts are reaching your phone."** PuTTY should say **all passing**.

That's it, it's working. From now on it checks your Pi every 30 minutes on its own, and sends a short "Pi-hole OK" report every morning at 5:30 AM. You can close PuTTY.

Part 6 (recommended): Help the Pi recover after a power outage

Only do this if the installer showed a NOTE in Part 4. Otherwise, skip it.

Why: the Pi has no clock battery. After a power outage it can start up with the wrong date and get stuck. This change lets it fix its own clock. It doesn't change anything for your other devices.

1. In PuTTY, paste this and press **Enter**:

```
nmcli -t -f NAME connection show --active
```

2. It prints one or two names. If one of them is **Wired connection 1**, paste these two lines and press **Enter**. The window may freeze for a few seconds, which is normal:

```
sudo nmcli connection modify "Wired connection 1" ipv4.dns "1.1.1.1 1.0.0.1"
ipv4.ignore-auto-dns yes
sudo nmcli connection up "Wired connection 1"
```

3. If it showed a different name (not **lo**), use that name in place of *Wired connection 1* in both lines, keeping the quote marks.

If PuTTY disconnects during step 2, just log in again as in Part 2. The change is saved.

When an alert arrives

Every alert says what's wrong and ends with a **Fix:** line telling you what to do. Most of the time you'll hear nothing at all.

Alert	What it means	What to do
Pi-hole OK (5:30 AM)	Daily report: all fine	Nothing
Fixed itself	Something hiccuped and the Pi restarted it	Nothing
Pi restarted	The Pi rebooted, usually a power blip	Nothing, unless it keeps happening
Switched to backup DNS	Part of Pi-hole stopped working, but the internet stays on through a backup	Follow the Fix line when you have time. It switches back by itself.
Pi hardware warning	Too hot, weak power supply, or the memory card is having trouble	Follow the Fix line soon
Pi-hole PROBLEM	Pi-hole is broken and the internet may be down	Follow the Fix line now
Pi SHUTTING DOWN	The Pi turned itself off to protect itself	Follow the FIRST line to get the internet back, then the Fix line

Too many alerts? Tap **Snooze 3h** under an alert to pause the repeats for 3 hours. Or tap the bell icon in ntfy to mute it for a while.

If the whole house loses internet and you can't reach the Pi: log into your router (usually its web page or app) and change its DNS setting back to automatic. That gets everyone online without the Pi.

If something goes wrong

What you see	What to do
PuTTY says **Access denied**	The password was wrong. Type it again slowly. Nothing shows while you type.
PuTTY or WinSCP **can't connect** or times out	Check the Pi's IP address again (Part 2), and that the Pi is plugged in with its lights on.
Paste doesn't work in PuTTY	Right-click inside the window. Ctrl+V doesn't work there.
No such file or directory after Part 4's command	The file isn't on the Pi. Redo Part 3, and drop the file on the right side without changing folders.
command not found in Part 5	Use this line instead: `sudo /usr/local/bin/pihole-watchdog.sh test`
No test message on the phone	Check the channel name in ntfy matches Part 4 exactly, check your phone allows notifications from ntfy, then run the test again.
A problem is listed instead of "all passing"	Read the Fix line it prints. That's what to do.

Turning it off

Log in with PuTTY (Part 2), paste this and press **Enter**:

```
sudo rm -f /etc/cron.d/pihole-watchdog
```

The checks stop. Your Pi-hole keeps blocking ads as normal. To turn the watchdog back on later, run the installer again (Part 4). You can also delete the channel in the ntfy app.